Dajing Documentation Project: Meta-Documentation

1 Overview

Dajing is an underdocumented Wu dialect spoken by approximately 450,000 people in the area north of the Qingjiang River in Yueqing City, Zhejiang Province. The community is currently experiencing a rapid language shift toward Mandarin, with fluency in the dialect declining among younger generations. The goal of the documentation project is to support the preservation of Dajing and the cultural heritage embedded in the language.

This variety of dialect is referred to by the speakers in Nange village, where I did my fieldwork, as "the local vernacular". It is also called Nange dialect, Dajing dialect, or Xianxi dialect, since Nange village is in Xianxi town near Dajing town (figure 2). I have chosen to refer to it as Dajing because it encompasses the larger area where a similar variety is spoken. (The variety spoken *in* Dajing city can be differentiated from the one spoken in Nange village by subtle pronunciation differences, but they are mutually intelligible.) According to native speakers of Dajing, other related dialects in these regions are all mutually intelligible to an extent, while differences in pronunciation and expression readily serve as cues for identifying the speaker's origin[1]. The Qingjiang River forms a key dividing line within the Yueqing dialect area: south of the river belongs to the Ou dialect subdivision (e.g., Yueqing dialect), while north of the river belongs to the Southern Taizhou dialect subdivision of the broader Taizhounese, which is phonologically closer to some subdivisions of Northern Wu. This places Dajing closer to Taizhounese, a more prominent and better-studied dialect[2].

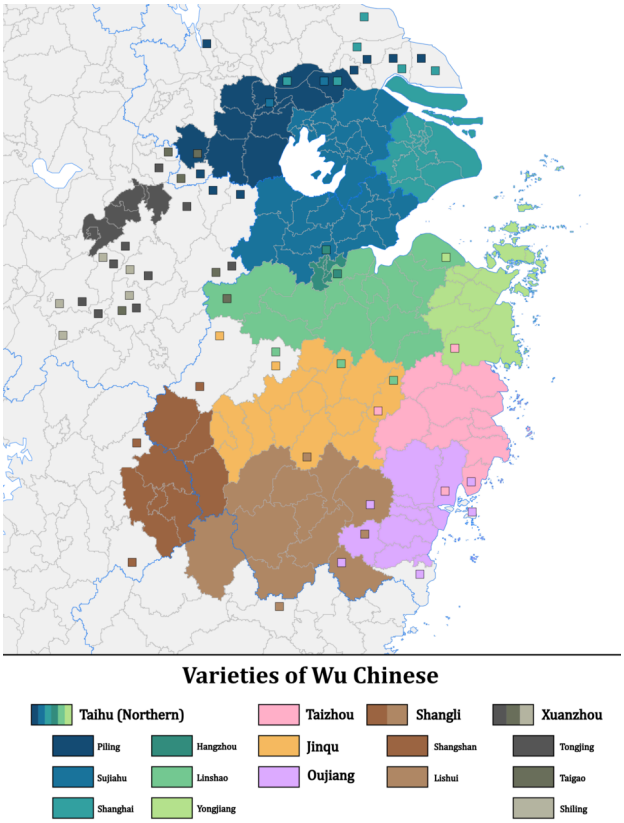


Figure 1: Map of Wu Chinese varieties (wikipedia), aligned with the 2nd edition of Language Atlas of China

[1] For example, according to one speaker of Dajing, the word for "above" is pronounced [ɐiemie] in Longxi, but [t͡suomie] in Xianxi.

[2] Wu is divided into Northern and Southern Wu, which are usually not mutually intelligible. Taizhounese is one of the southern subgroups, which can be further subdivided into many local varieties. Speakers are generally only familiar with their local and neighbouring dialects but not their affinity with the larger Wu group. The barrier of mountain ranges in Zhejiang Province have formed natural administrative boundaries and also dialectal boundaries, even leading to situations where dialects can differ drastically within short distances. For example, the Yandang Mountain creates the division between the Taizhou dialect on its northern side and the Wenzhou (Ou) dialect on the southern side. (Zhejiang Provincial Linguistic Society, "Zhejiang Wu Dialect Sub-regions", *Linguistics Annual* (*语言学年刊*), Issue 3, Sep 10, 1985) https://www.163.com/news/article/E61IFPO9000187UE.html



Figure 2: Map showing Dajing Town (Dajingzhen 大荆镇), Xianxi Town (Xianxizhen 仙溪镇), Longxi Township (Longxixiang 龙西乡), and Nange Village



Figure 3: Map showing Taizhou, Dajing Town, Nange Village, and Qingjiang river.

Although no current sources specifically describes Dajing, there appears to be relatively comprehensive descriptive material on Taizhou dialect, including its phonology, its subdivisions, phonological comparisons between the subdivisions and with Mandarin, lexical entries and common words, notable grammatical structures, and texts (such as stories like "The Crow and the Pitcher"[3]). A certain amount of research articles on Taizhou dialect also exist, though none appear to focus on Dajing. Aside from academic scholarship, videos uploaded by native speakers illustrating or showcasing different Zhejiang or

[3] The story appears in an encyclopedic source: https://baike.baidu.com/item/台州话/7872477#sup-1
Which cited the following sources: Cao, Zhigeng (曹志耘), *Phonetic Study of Southern Wu* (南部吴语语音研究), The Commercial Press, 2002; Yan, Yiming (颜逸明), *An Overview of Wu* (吴语概说), Shanghai Education Press, 1994; You, Rujie (游汝杰), *Phonological correspondences among Wu dialect groups* (吴语内部各片的音韵对应), Shanghai Education Press, 2003.

Wenzhou dialects can be found online. No dedicated repository exists, but many articles (presumably written by people interested in the dialect) on the words and pronunciation of Taizhou dialect can be found, as well as a forum dedicated to the discussion of Taizhounese. Most recently, in June 2025, *《浙江方言常用字典》* (*Common Words Dictionary of Zhejiang Dialects*) was published.

This documentation project aims to develop a phonological description of Dajing, which likely shares the diverse and unique phonological characteristics typical of Wu languages. For instance, Wu languages are characterised by their tripartite division of initial stop consonants (preservation of voiced stop onsets of medieval Chinese) and the checked tone as a glottal stop[4]. Additionally, they are known for their complex tone systems[5]. Rose (1990), in a study of tone sandhi of the Zhenhai Variety of Wu Chinese, shows that the 6 citation tones can be related to the 20 different forms in disyllabic lexical sandhi. While Wu languages also possess unique syntactic structures, their morphosyntactic systems tend to exhibit greater similarity to other Chinese languages than do their phonological systems. Consequently, existing scholarship on the broader Taizhou dialect group, particularly in English-language literature, has focused heavily on phonological phenomena, including tonal register systems, phonation types, acoustic properties, and diachronic change. A phonological analysis of Dajing will provide empirical data relevant to broader theoretical questions in phonetics and phonology, such as the nature of tone sandhi processes in Wu varieties, mechanisms governing the complex sandhi patterns, the realisation of the initial voiced stops, etc.

This project and fieldwork trip are funded by the Seidel Scholars Grant, which required a completed and presentable outcome – a website that now hosts some of my processed materials (see section 2.2). Although the funding period concluded in September 2025, I hope to continue developing the project (see section 5). During its conception, the project was initially titled “Linguistic Tapestry: the Dajing Language Archival Project”, and the abstract stated that “this project aims to develop a multimodal digital repository to support the preservation and revitalization of Dajing. [...] The project includes fieldwork in a village where Dajing is spoken, Nange, collecting audio-visual recordings from native speakers across age groups and genders. [...] The recordings will help document Dajing's linguistic features and lexicon as well as cultural practices. By documenting Dajing during a critical window of relatively full community use, the initiative offers a timely and vital contribution to its linguistic preservation and cultural memory.”

2 Approaches

2.1 Collaborative Approach

This project strives to be collaborative, ethical, and respectful of community ownership of cultural and linguistic knowledge. Community members have been actively involved throughout the process, including proposing content, offering explanations, reviewing materials, sharing personal stories, and guiding decisions about what should or should not be made public. Recognising that grammar and dictionaries describing the language system are not sufficient representation of a language, by documentation, I will take the “holistic and situated” approach that aims to truthfully demonstrate the complexities of spoken language (Himmelmann 1998, 2006).

[4] Norman, Jerry (1988), Chinese, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, ISBN 978-0-521-29653-3; Chao, 1967.
[5] Rose, Phil; Toda, Takako (1994), "A Typology of Tone Sandhi Rules in Northern Wu", Current Issues in Sino-Tibetan Linguistics, Osaka: 267–27

For the larger goal of this project, the main stakeholders are speakers in the community across different generations[6]. Potential stakeholders include the village council and local schools, though they were not involved at this stage due to the project's small scale. For both the local and academic communities, my responsibility is to strive for an accurate representation of the speech community's language. My language consultants, most of whom are family members, provided knowledge on local life and culture, helped interpret the recordings, and offered transcription and translation suggestions. The recording, storing, processing, transcription, and translation of all recordings were completed by me with their assistance.

2.2 Timeline

The project started in May 2025 under the supervision of Dr Grenoble, and I took the first field trip to Dajing in August–September 2025. During the field trip, I collected audio recordings of wordlist, elicited materials from stimuli, community members discussing traditions, celebrations, events, and childhood life, procedural texts, and video recordings of cooking procedures and various local objects and practices. The resulting website hosts a collection of processed data collected in fieldwork. I expect to carry out further fieldwork in 2026-27 as well as produce more distributable outputs from the collected materials (see section 5).

2.3 Methods

To collect linguistic data, I used a combination of elicitation and interview techniques. More spontaneous production during interviews can help generate data that bypass the methodological disadvantages of elicitation, which has low ecological validity (Lüpke 2010).

Wordlist: The Dialect Research Word List is a widely-used list in Chinese dialect research. It is based on the Guangyun, a Chinese rhyme dictionary that was compiled from 1007 to 1008 and heavily used in early work on the reconstruction of Middle Chinese. I used part of the list to gather preliminary information about the phoneme inventory and tones as well as lexical data. One challenge encountered was in the use of the common language (in this case the Chinese writing system) and lack of a direct translation equivalent, as mentioned in Lüpke (2010). While using the wordlist has benefits of comparability, it might fail to reveal some present-day phonological properties since it is only grounded in a historical analysis of the system that has now evolved and is constantly under different influences. This limitation should be recognised while drawing any conclusions from using the Research Word List.

Picture Stimuli: I used picture stimuli for both prompting known words with contrasting features on the wordlist and eliciting words in a certain semantic category (body parts[7]) or complete descriptions (topological expressions[8]). This is still a staged communicative event, but the use of non-linguistic prompts allow speakers to produce less confined expressions.

[6] In the case of Dajing and the village I visited, the concept of an elder does not exist.
[7] The *body parts* stimuli consist of cartoon drawings depicting different body parts.
[8] Bowerman, Melissa & Eric Pederson. 1992. Topological relations picture series. In Stephen C. Levinson (ed.), Space stimuli kit 1.2: November 1992, 51. Nijmegen: Max Planck Institute for Psycholinguistics.

Interviews and Participant Input: The interviews were semi-structured with a few pre-determined questions and topics, which tend to grow into free discussions that are highly naturalistic and rich in vocabulary, though more difficult to parse. I have also recorded materials upon the suggestion of some participants of their topics of interest, such as riddles, introducing tools, and pronunciation of certain words.

3 Ethical Considerations

In a language-documentation fieldwork context, the activities themselves are unlikely to cause significant distress to the participants; however, there are several points that deserve attention.

Informed consent: In most cases, I used verbal consent instead of written consent, which is more culturally appropriate and accessible. The project and specific tasks were explained to the participant before they gave their verbal consent, and the process was audio recorded. Written consent is used when the participant is literate and has a sufficient understanding of how academic research operates. One challenge I have encountered is the speakers' unfamiliarity with the norms of academic projects and research. This contributes to the "ultimate implausibility" of informed consent where speakers didn't fully understand the project's goal (and didn't seem particularly concerned about doing so) (Dorian 2010). One solution is to provide them with more concrete examples and practice explaining the project in simple terms, show them the previously produced outputs, and check in regularly with each speaker I work with.

Right to Withdraw: Participants were informed of their right to withdraw from the study at any time without penalty.

Privacy: Recordings cannot be simply viewed as linguistic documents without regard to their content (Dorian 2010). Therefore, we need to pay special attention to any personal content being made public. While participants are asked for explicit consent regarding public sharing, some may initially be uncertain about having their voices, their way of speaking, or their cultural knowledge accessible in a digital format. Even with the option for anonymity, the small size of the community means that voices or cultural knowledge might be recognizable to other community members. I made an effort to fully inform participants of the potential ways their data could be used, and as Austin (2010) notes, it is important to make regular checks as informed consent can change over time as the project and the speakers' participation progress.

Community: I am an insider researcher with deep personal connections to Nange village (where my parents were born), which provides me with necessary insight into local social dynamics, communication patterns, and cultural sensitivities. I am equally aware of the minor social pressure to participate due to the existing relationships we have with potential participants, including extended family members. Topics that might raise concerns about appropriate sharing or representation of sensitive cultural knowledge, especially topics considered taboo by older generations, such as words relating to death, were not recorded to respect speaker decision.

Compensation: In Nange village, direct monetary transactions between community members, especially those with family or social connections, go against local cultural norms. I offered compensation in the

form of meaningful gifts to align with traditional practices of reciprocity and respect within the community. In practice, older generations more often would refuse the gifts or compensation when they were simply helping based on the friendly relationship they had with us. The younger generation tend to be more receptive to the value of being compensated for their time and contribution to research. For those who had refused, I would seek alternative ways to compensate people, such assisting them in other ways, or buying them gifts for another more culturally appropriate occasion.

Speaker Perspectives: As discussed in section 2.1, this project aims to be collaborative and participatory, making it more relevant to those who would benefit from it, inviting different perspectives and discussion, and developing resources for the community. It is crucial to recognise and respect the speakers' insight and knowledge about the language as another valuable source of information. While the current focus is more on linguistic research, I would like to incorporate the speakers' own priorities and interests into the project.

4 Data

Currently in this project, a total of 12 speakers are consulted, and recordings from 11 are kept (one withdrew their data). There were 5 male speakers and 6 female speakers, aged between 30 to 68 years. 5 of them are immediate family members of mine or relatives, and the other ones are acquaintances or neighbours.

The data collected include approximately 7 hours of audio recording (67 recordings in total) and 40 minutes of video material. The content of the audio recordings include participants naming body parts and describing topological relations from visual stimuli, producing words either directly from a wordlist or from image stimuli, describing recipe procedures, telling stories and riddles, and being interviewed about cultural matters. The recordings were conducted in private rooms with the researcher and the speaker seated side-by-side and the recording device positioned near the speaker, unless otherwise noted. Audio was recorded using Awesome Voice Recorder on iPhone Xs.

The more structured forms of elicitation (wordlists, image stimuli) are used for obtaining lexical items, and the less structured interview formats are effective to get diverse, natural speech production and for understanding the sociocultural context in which the language is used. Not every speaker completed every task (see metadata in Lameta; see section 2.3 for task details).

4.1 Suggestion for improvements

Future recordings should be made with a greater awareness of the use and placement of devices to capture optimal audio information with all the necessary skills and arrangements (Nathan 2010). They should also be accompanied by video as it captures visual information such as gestures that are essential to language use (cf. Kendon 2004), as language is multi-modal grounded in real in-person interactions (cf. Clark 1996) (Seyfeddinipur 2020).

Future metadata should be more comprehensive to include all potentially salient information, including the people present at the scene of recording, the setting and location, the position of things, etc. For the purpose of language documentation, which is to provide long-lasting, comprehensive data of a language,

clear, complete, and accountable metadata (in archiving) provides the necessary contextual information to interpret the knowledge we have stored – "metadata is required [...] for the very management, identification, retrieval, and understanding of the data within the documentation project" (Austin 2015).

4.2 Processing Notes

The metadata about the project and each session is kept in Lameta, and the workflow of transcribing each audio recording is as follows:

1. Pre-processing in Praat, deleting interviewer instructions and explanations, overly long silence, interruptions of any sort; for wordlist-type elicitation, trim to retain only the relevant responses.
2. The processed file is imported into ELAN, and transcription and translation are completed accordingly. See below for transcription and translation notes.
3. For further analysis, the ELAN files can be imported into FLex to develop the lexicon and automate some of the glossing process.

Transcription and translation notes:

The main parent tier in transcription is the phonemic IPA transcription (Transcription-txt-wuu), segmented into intonation phrases. Its dependent tiers consist of:

- Words-txt-wuu: IPA transcription* further segmented into individual syllables (characters)
- OrthTrans-txt-wuu: Orthographic transcription in Dajing (adopting corresponding Chinese characters) (by intonation phrase)
- Tone-gls-wuu: Tone (word-by-word)
- Words-txt-en: English translation (word-by-word)
- Translation-gls-en: Gloss (word-by-word)
- Translation-txt-en: English free translation (by intonation phrase)
- Translation-txt-cmn: Mandarin free translation (by intonation phrase)
- Transcription notes

*One challenge in transcribing Chinese dialects is that one can use either the IPA transcription, a romanisation system designed for the dialect, or characters, which requires determining whether the transcribed sound should correspond to a certain character, and if so, which one—a task with varying degrees of difficulty. All three methods are quite commonly used. The IPA system provides a clear, unambiguous representation of sound; the orthography using Chinese characters shows the most semantic information, is more accessible, and can be informed by historical forms. In cases where a romanisation has been developed (often by linguists or missionaries), it is also used to represent the pronunciation but might risk incorrectly showing phonemic contrasts.

The interviews and cultural texts have been translated and currently in the transcription process. The elicited materials are still undergoing the initial process of removing non-essential information and proper segmentation. Time permitting, potential future work on the corpus could include building towards a corpus that can be used to develop tools for automating alignment or segmentation tasks, or even producing transcripts[9].

[9] c.f. Omnilingual ASR, an open-source multilingual speech recognition model that enables communities to introduce unserved languages with only a handful of data samples. https://arxiv.org/abs/2511.09690

Metadata notes:
In Lameta, each session is labeled with a session id in the form of "speaker code_task name_date_recording number", for instance "001_bodyparts_250720_1". The recording number is used when there are multiple recordings for a single session or task. The session's date, title, genre, and information for context/location (when available) are also recorded. For each speaker, we record their name, date of birth, assigned code, linguistic background and areas lived.

5 Future Work

Different objectives require different types of data to be collected. The following provides a brief discussion based on various potential goals. Regardless of the main objective, as part of the collaborative approach to language documentation, the output of the project should include a part that is accessible and useful for the community. One way to do this is to produce materials (such as dictionaries and grammars) in the dialect itself (Austin 2010).

Phonological linguistics research will require specifically designed stimuli, for example to assess a sound change. These types of material are usually less of interest to the speakers, but they can inform the standardisation of the orthography, which might, in turn, affect the speakers. If prioritising the goal of building comprehensive documentation and archiving, we should record as diverse as possible a range of communicative events across different registers and contexts with varied speaker populations and topics. It is important to note that a skewed sample may result in an unrepresentative record coming to stand for the speech community as a whole (Dorian 2010). I will also be mindful of including metacommentary on language use and linguistic reflections or debates as integral components of the documentation.

If the Nange (and greater) community wishes to push for revitalisation and community-based efforts, then we should prioritise documenting information that is of interest to the community and producing useful materials (e.g. educational materials for children or possibly adults). In the integrative model, the production of educational materials is integrated into the language documentation corpus, which can equally serve as a resource for linguistic research. When the local people decide the content and purpose of the corpus, the corpus often includes the goal of building educational materials from the start (Mosel 2012).

The general plan for future directions of this project is to consult relevant parties for suggestions of documentation content and give equal priority to these recommendations.

With community members: identify a group (5-10) of speakers from various age groups and professions and interview them informally about their attitude and needs about documentation; share the output of the first field trip (i.e. the website and subsequent analysis) with the community; collect suggestions and feedback from the community either in-person or online (e.g. groupchats) to inform the next steps of the project.

Local institutions: contact local schools or community centres to inquire about possible needs and goals or existing efforts towards documentation of the dialect. Reach out to the regional university and see if

any relevant work has been done. Requires time and resources to get in touch with the institutions but most likely needs only a single visit.

Archiving: archiving makes the collected data as long-lasting and usable as possible, available for later mobilization for language maintenance, community revitalisation efforts, and research (Berez-Kroeker & Ryan Henke 2018; Conathan 2011). Ultimately, I would like to archive the recording, accompanying analysis and notes in both their raw form and more polished format. With the explicit consent from the community, the archived materials would be open access. One possible platform to deposit my data is the Chinese Language Resources Protection Project. Reach out after having a decent size of processed data.

Orthography: prepare a representative list of words and organise a meeting with multiple consultants to discuss how they should be written. This activity will also inform the possibility of collaborating with speakers in transcribing longer conversational or narrative recordings. Requires one or more meetings with 3-5 people; preliminary phonological analysis should be done before the meeting.

Educational material and general output: develop posters, booklets, and educational videos. This will require identifying the target audience and potential channels or platforms for distribution. Offering materials written or spoken in the local dialect can foster a sense of belonging and pride in cultural heritage among community members. The development of such materials necessitates consulting local speakers of various ages, including teenagers, to gather suggestions and perspectives on potential challenges, people's willingness to learn, and their sense of necessity regarding language preservation. Requires multiple visits and interviews to ensure adequate community input.

Community contribution and engagement: build a platform that provides prompts and invites community members to make their own recordings while facilitating the upload process. This will be done potentially through a mini-programme on Wechat as the app is widely used, and people would be very familiar with the mini-programme interface for different functionalities. Requires a channel to publicise and mobilise the community.

Linked resources

Description of Taizhou dialect: from Party History Research Office of the Taizhou Municipal Committee, *Taizhou History and Records*. http://tzsz.zjtz.gov.cn/art/2019/3/5/art_122920668154284656.html
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